

Preparing for a Telephone Interview

Things to Remember:

1. Don't read too much into the way an interviewer responds to your answers – some people – especially HR professionals have great “poker faces” always act as if things are going excellent.
2. Always project a “positive” image. Don't talk negatively about past employers or position responsibilities. You can justify your decisions without “bashing” anyone.
3. Clear the room – evict the kids and pets, the music, tv, close the door, and go somewhere you KNOW you'll have clear cell service.
4. Speak slowly and enunciate clearly and give short BUT detailed answers,
5. Take your time — it's perfectly acceptable to take a moment or two to collect your thoughts
6. DON'T interrupt the interviewer
7. Smile when responding – even if you have to force yourself or think it's silly – do it - it affects the tone and quality of your voice over the phone.
8. Fill out the worksheet included in this packet as this will help to refresh your memory about your past accomplishments before you get asked the questions. You won't have to appear to be “digging” for answers.
9. **Listen first:** Usually, the interviewer will set the stage. He or she will talk about expectations, why the person before you left, what it takes to be successful in this company and what the major challenges will be. Take notes so you are able to respond to all these points when it is your turn to talk.
10. *The leitmotif of a successful interview is finding things that you have in common.* Flagging them helps you bond with your future boss or the human resources manager. Look for ways to make these connections – for example, by saying, “Sounds familiar: We had a similar situation at company ABC. Here is what I did. And these were the results.”
11. **Then talk:** When we are in front of someone, we can send and receive visual cues. On the phone, we must make a good impression purely with our voices. Drink as much water as you need to avoid having to clear your throat. If you haven't talked in several hours, do some voice exercises before the call. Posture is important too and has an impact on your voice. Stand, or make sure you sit up very straight, during the call.
12. The money question – If you get asked about your current compensation – answer honestly and accurately – don't hedge. Make sure to include all the things that make up your compensation – Base, Bonus, Vacation, 401K, Stock options. **When they ask, “what are you looking for in an offer?”** – tell them you don't have a “hard” number in mind go over with them your current compensation and then say that you certainly would expect to improve on your current compensation and leave it at that...if you lock yourself into a number that is the number they will use for any offer or consideration when weighing candidates.

13. Prepare 3-5 questions on the company and role that you need answered in order to determine how interested you are in moving forward in the process.

ANSWERING EXPERIENCE QUESTIONS THE RIGHT WAY

- **FIRST RULE – Answers need to be between 1 – 3 minutes in length.** If it's too short no one will believe you, and if you're too long, you'll be considered insensitive and boring. This advice will only work if you've done something comparable. It will backfire if you try to fake it.
- **SECOND RULE – Structure your answers using the S.T.A.R.C.H. principle.**
 - S** = situation – Explain the situation surrounding your example
 - T** = task – What task were you trying to accomplish
 - A** = action – What actions did you take to accomplish the task
 - R** = results – What were the results of this action
 - CH** = change – What would you do differently this time because of what you learned

****Important** – When giving these answers use both the words “I” and “we” in your examples. If you only use the word “I” during your response you come across as arrogant and not team player. If you over use the word “we” you appear as a follower who is incapable of functioning under their own initiatives.

Lastly – and this is **VERY IMPORTANT** – as soon as you hang up the phone please shoot me a quick email that answers the following questions, so I am prepared for when the client calls me back.

Why do you feel you can do this job?

Why do you feel you want this job?

What about the company/position is attractive to you?

What red flags came up as a result of your interview?

What questions do you still want answered?

Do you want to continue the interviewing process for this position?